A SERMON FOR THE PULPIT

The Valley Breathes

A sermon on Ezekiel

THE BIG IDEA

God is not intimidated by a valley of dry bones. His word assembles the dead, His Spirit gives them breath, and the risen King leads them home.

PRIMARY TEXT	Ezekiel 37:1–14
ALSO READ	Ezekiel 36:22–38; 34:1–31; 37:15–28; Daniel 12:1–3; John 3:1–8; John 10:1–18; John 11:17–27; Acts 2:1–41; Romans 8:1–11; Ephesians 2:1–10; 1 Corinthians 15:1–28
TIME	55–60 minutes, including a 3–5 minute response.

Scripture quotations are ESV. Swap to your pulpit translation freely.

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Introduction: The valley full of bones

The first thing Ezekiel wants you to see is the ground.

Not a cemetery. Not a tidy row of graves with stones and flowers. A valley. Open. Exposed. And the floor of the valley is covered with bones.

The text says they were very many. Then it says they were very dry.

The Hebrew does not rush. It uses the word "behold" twice. Behold, there were very many on the surface of the valley. Behold, they were very dry. The prophet is not describing a bad week. He is standing in the middle of a slaughterhouse that has been left in the sun.

You can almost hear the dust move.

Ezekiel does not say how long he walked among them. Long enough to see that there was no sound. Long enough to see that there was no wind. Long enough for the valley to become a question.

There are no mourners. No names on the graves. No one is arranging a funeral. The bones are simply there, scattered across the valley like a canceled future.

Then God asks the prophet a question.

"Son of man, can these bones live?"

That is the question of the text. It is also the question of every human life at some point. Can this marriage live? Can this church live? Can this faith live? Can this hope live? Can I live?

The prophet does not answer with a strategy. He says, "O Lord GOD, you know."

That is the right answer, and it is not a dodge. It is the beginning of resurrection.

The valley is real. The bones are real. The dryness is real. But the God who made the valley is standing in it, and He is not intimidated by a single bone.

The big idea of this sermon is this: God is not intimidated by a valley of dry bones. His word assembles the dead, His Spirit gives them breath, and the risen King leads them home.

The valley is not the end of the story. The valley is where God speaks.

Let us walk through it with Ezekiel. There are five things to see.

Movement 1: The death we cannot deny

Ezekiel is a priest.

He was trained to serve in the temple. He knew the songs of Zion, the smell of sacrifice, the order of the courts. He belonged to the house of God. Then the Babylonians came.

The first wave of exiles was taken in 597 BC. Ezekiel was among them. He lived by the Kebar canal in Babylon, far from Jerusalem, far from the temple, far from everything he had been trained to do. In that place, the word of the LORD came to him. The glory of God appeared to him by the river. The same glory that had once filled the temple now met him in a pagan land.

But the glory had also departed the temple. Ezekiel had seen that in a vision. The cherubim lifted their wings, and the presence of the LORD went out of the city. The house was left without its inhabitant. The people were left without their center. The exile was not just a political event. It was a covenant funeral.

By the time we come to Ezekiel 37, the news has gotten worse. Jerusalem has fallen. The city has been burned. The temple is a pile of stones. The king is blinded in chains. The people are scattered. The exiles have had time to settle in Babylon, to build houses, to plant gardens, to learn the language of their captors. And with the passing of time, something else has settled in them: despair.

They say it out loud in verse 11. "Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost; we are indeed cut off."

They are not being dramatic. They are being accurate.

The exile had lasted long enough for the first generation to die. The people who had sung the songs of Zion by the rivers of Babylon were now burying their parents and raising children who had never seen the temple. The promises were still true, but they were becoming someone else's memory.

Joseph made Israel swear to carry his bones out of Egypt (Genesis 50:25). These bones had been carried nowhere. They were the evidence that a promise had stalled.

They know they are dead as a nation. The promises to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob seem to have run into the ground. The promises to David seem to have died with the last king. The land is occupied. The temple is gone. The nations are laughing. What is left?

Bones.

The vision is not a metaphor for low self-esteem. It is a picture of a people under judgment, beyond their own resources, with no future they can manufacture. The bones are not merely tired. They are dry. There is no marrow. There is no moisture. There is no hidden life waiting to be uncovered. They are dead.

The text says they were "very many." This is not one man's grave. This is the whole house of Israel. It is a nation-sized death. The valley is a battlefield, and the army is gone.

That is the first thing we must see. We cannot get to resurrection without first getting to death.

We tend to hurry past death. We say, "We know how the story ends." But the prophet makes us stand in the valley. He makes us look at the bones. He does not let us skip the funeral on the way to the hope.

Why?

Because a resurrection is only as glorious as the death is real.

If you call a broken marriage a rough patch, resurrection is a nice idea. If you call a dead son a set of possibilities, resurrection is a platitude. But if the bones are dry, if hope is lost, if the tomb is sealed, then "the LORD raises the dead" is not a slogan. It is the only news that can save.

The exiles were not wrong about the bones. They were wrong about the size of God's mercy.

We can be wrong in the same way.

Some of us are standing in a valley right now.

Maybe it is a dream that died. You worked for years, sacrificed, prayed, and then watched it fall apart. Maybe it is a child who has walked away. Maybe it is a marriage that has gone quiet. Maybe it is a church that feels like a building with a congregation still attached. Maybe it is a sin that has beaten you so often that you have stopped expecting anything but the same fall. Maybe it is grief that has not lifted, depression that sits on your chest, a diagnosis that rearranged all your plans.

You know what dry bones look like.

The first step out of the valley is not to deny that you are in it.

The psalmists did not say, "My soul is fine." They said, "My soul is cast down within me." They said, "I am poured out like water." They said, "Out of the depths I cry to you, O LORD." The Bible is not afraid of the valley. It is afraid of the lie that there is no valley.

If you are in the valley, stop pretending the bones are alive. Tell God the truth. He can handle it. He has been in the valley longer than you have.

But the valley is not only a place of death. It is a place of meeting. The LORD is about to ask Ezekiel a question.

Movement 2: The question we cannot answer

"Son of man, can these bones live?"

The question is strange, because God knows the answer.

He is not asking for information. He is not hoping Ezekiel will supply a strategy. He is exposing the prophet's heart. He is bringing him to the end of himself so that he can see the beginning of God.

Notice the title: "Son of man." It means a human being, a mortal, a child of dust. It is the way God addresses Ezekiel throughout the book, more than ninety times. The title keeps reminding the prophet that he is not the answer. He is a man.

"Can these bones live?"

If you ask that question of a doctor, you get a prognosis. If you ask it of a scientist, you get biology. If you ask it of an optimist, you get a plan. If you ask it of a pessimist, you get a shrug. If you ask it of a prophet, you get a prayer.

"O Lord GOD, you know."

That is the answer of faith.

It is not a yes. It is not a no. It is a handoff. Ezekiel refuses to be the authority on what God can do. He does not know how dead bones could live. He does not have a model. He does not have a program. He knows the one who knows.

That is the grammar of faith in the valley.

Notice that God does not rebuke the prophet for not knowing. He does not say, "You should have more faith." He asks the question, and He waits. The silence is a grace. It gives Ezekiel room to be a man before he is a messenger.

We often answer the question in one of two ways.

The first is optimism. We say, "Yes, of course they can live. With the right plan, the right leader, the right effort, the right attitude, we can turn this around." We put the answer in our hands, and we become the savior of our own story.

The second is despair. We say, "No, the bones are dry. It is over. There is no use." We also put the answer in our hands, and we pronounce a sentence that only God has the right to pronounce.

Both answers are too small.

The prophet puts the whole thing in God's hands.

"You know."

Do you see what that does to the pressure? You do not have to know how God will raise the dead. You do not have to have a five-year plan for your valley. You have to bring the bones to the one who knows.

This is not passivity. Ezekiel will obey the next command. He will speak to the bones. But his obedience is not the ground of his hope. His hope is in the character and power of God.

The difference between optimism and faith is not the size of the expectation. It is the object. Optimism expects the circumstances to change. Faith expects God to be God, whether or not they change on our schedule.

There is a great Bible sentence in Genesis 18:14. The LORD asks, "Is anything too hard for the LORD?"

There is another one in Jeremiah 32:17. "Ah, Lord GOD! It is you who have made the heavens and the earth by your great power and by your outstretched arm! Nothing is too hard for you."

There is another one in Romans 4, where Paul describes Abraham's faith. Abraham was almost a hundred years old. Sarah's womb was dead. The promise seemed impossible. But Abraham "did not weaken in faith when he considered his own body, now as good as dead, or when he considered the barrenness of Sarah's womb. No unbelief made him waver concerning the promise of God, but he grew strong in his faith as he gave glory to God, fully convinced that God was able to do what he had promised."

That is the answer. Faith does not deny the deadness. It looks at the deadness and then looks at God.

The question "Can these bones live?" is a mirror.

Do you believe God is able?

Not "will God do exactly what I want, when I want, in the way I want." That is not faith; that is a demand. Faith says, "I do not know the timetable. I do not know the method. I do not know what the resurrection will look like. But I know you are the God who raises the dead."

The prophet's answer is short enough to memorize. It is a sentence to say in the dark.

"O Lord GOD, you know."

When the diagnosis comes, say it.

When the child does not come home, say it.

When the church is empty, say it.

When you do not know what to do with the dry bones of your own heart, say it.

"You know."

The world will tell you to give up or to take control. The gospel tells you to hand the impossible to God.

Then God tells the prophet to do something that makes no sense at all.

Movement 3: The word we cannot manufacture

"Prophesy over these bones, and say to them, O dry bones, hear the word of the LORD."

This is absurd.

Imagine the scene. A valley full of bones. No lungs. No ears. No brain. No congregation. And God says, "Preach to them."

Not about them. To them.

"O dry bones, hear the word of the LORD."

The prophet is not asked to be clever. He is not asked to make the bones feel better about themselves. He is not asked to give them a vision statement. He is asked to speak the word of God.

And the word is not a suggestion.

“Thus says the Lord GOD to these bones: Behold, I will cause breath to enter you, and you shall live. And I will lay sinews upon you, and will cause flesh to come upon you, and cover you with skin, and put breath in you, and you shall live, and you shall know that I am the LORD.”

Count the “I will” statements. God is doing the work. God is the subject of the resurrection. The prophet is the voice. He is not the life.

So Ezekiel prophesies.

He speaks to the bones.

And something happens.

“There was a sound, and behold, a rattling, and the bones came together, bone to its bone.”

That is one of the most beautiful sentences in the Bible.

Bone to its bone.

The scattered becomes ordered. The dismembered becomes a body. The chaos becomes structure. When I was a boy, I had a toy skeleton. I remember how satisfying it was to fit the parts together. But this is not a toy. This is a battlefield. And the bones are finding each other.

Then sinews come. Then flesh. Then skin. The body is rebuilt from the inside out. The skeleton is no longer a pile. It is a person.

But there is no breath in them.

That is the pause.

The corpse is assembled, but it is still a corpse.

This is one of the most important details in the vision. It would be easy to miss because we are waiting for the resurrection. But God wants us to see it. A body can be put together and still be dead.

This is a picture of religion without the Spirit.

I do not say that lightly. We can have bones in order. We can have a full building, correct doctrine, beautiful music, a budget, a calendar, a leadership pipeline. We can have all the parts. And we can be dead.

A church can be assembled and lifeless.

A Christian can be assembled and lifeless.

A preacher can have a sermon and no breath.

I have seen buildings full of people who were faithful, orthodox, and tired. I have seen the opposite too: noise, motion, and no fear of God. The first has a body and no breath. The second has a pulse and no skeleton. Ezekiel's valley warns the first and corrects the second.

The vision asks us a hard question: are we satisfied with bones in order?

It is easier to count bones than to depend on the Spirit. It is easier to build a body than to pray for the wind. We can manage structure. We cannot manage the breath.

That is why prayer is not an accessory to ministry. It is the admission that we are not the life. A sermon can take hours and still be a corpse. A service can run without a mistake and still be a tomb. The question is not whether everything worked. The question is whether God breathed.

The prophet does what he is commanded. He speaks. The bones come together. But only God can give life.

Do you see the humility this demands?

The power is not in the prophet's style. It is not in his voice. It is not in his ability to create a moment. The word of the LORD is powerful, but the servant of the LORD is not the Lord. We preach; God quickens. We plant; God gives life. We speak; the Spirit breathes.

This is why a preacher should be both bold and humble. Bold, because the word of God is powerful. Humble, because the power is not ours. We do not manufacture a resurrection with good production. We do not manipulate people into new life. We speak the truth and pray for the wind.

Isaiah 55 says that the word of God is like rain and snow that does not return empty. It accomplishes the purpose for which it was sent. Hebrews 4 says that the word of God is living and active. The word is powerful. But the same Bible tells us that the letter kills and the Spirit gives life. The word is the sword of the Spirit. Without the Spirit, we have a sword and no arm.

The bones respond. That is grace. But they are not alive yet.

The first stage of the vision is not the resurrection. It is the assembling. It is the mercy of God getting the corpse ready. And it is not enough.

Do you know what this means for your work?

You may be called to speak to a valley that looks completely dead. You may be called to teach a group that is not listening, love a person who is not responding, serve a church that is not

growing, or confess the truth in a place where it is not welcome. You may see nothing but bones.

Keep speaking.

But do not stop there. Do not become a technician of bones. Do not settle for an assembly line of dry religion. Speak the word, and pray for the breath.

The prophet is about to learn the second half of the lesson. The body is intact. The valley is still a graveyard. Then God speaks again.

Movement 4: The breath we cannot command

“Prophesy to the breath; prophesy, son of man, and say to the breath, Thus says the Lord GOD: Come from the four winds, O breath, and breathe on these slain, that they may live.”

The Hebrew word is ruach.

It can mean wind. It can mean breath. It can mean spirit.

The translators have to choose one word at a time, but the text is playing on all three. The prophet is told to speak to the ruach. The ruach comes from the four winds. The ruach enters the bodies. The dead come alive.

This is the language of creation.

In Genesis 2, the LORD God formed the man from the dust of the ground and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life. The man became a living creature. Dust plus breath equals life. It is not dust plus dust. It is not bones plus bones. It is God’s breath in God’s creation.

Ezekiel’s valley is a new creation.

The graves are full of dust. The bones are dry. Then the Spirit comes.

The vision does not say the bones manufactured their own breath. It does not say the prophet controlled the wind. It does not say the size of the congregation determined the amount of life. It says the breath came.

The prophet prophesies. The breath enters. They live. They stand on their feet.

An exceedingly great army.

The valley is now full of standing people.

Do you feel the shift? A moment ago, the valley was a graveyard. Now it is a muster. The dead are not only alive; they are on their feet. They are ready. They are an army.

That is what the Spirit does. He does not just make people feel better. He makes them stand.

This is not a promise that every church will be large or every life will be easy. It is a promise that God can turn a valley of death into a living people.

The Spirit is the difference between a body and a person.

The Spirit is the difference between a religion and a relationship.

The Spirit is the difference between a correct idea and a new heart.

The Bible says a lot about the Spirit, and it does not reduce Him to a feeling. The Spirit is God's presence and power. He convicts the world of sin, righteousness, and judgment. He regenerates dead sinners. He adopts us into God's family. He produces love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. He gives gifts to the church. He seals us for the day of redemption. He is the down payment of our inheritance.

And He is the one who raises the dead.

Romans 8 says, "If the Spirit of him who raised Jesus from the dead dwells in you, he who raised Christ Jesus from the dead will also give life to your mortal bodies through his Spirit who dwells in you."

That is the same ruach. The same Spirit who raised the bones in Ezekiel's valley raised Jesus from the tomb. The same Spirit who raised Jesus lives in His people.

This is why the church is not a museum of dry bones. It is a resurrection community.

But we must be careful here. The Spirit is not a force we can harness. Jesus said, "The wind blows where it wishes, and you hear its sound, but you do not know where it comes from or where it goes. So it is with everyone who is born of the Spirit." The wind is sovereign. We do not schedule it. We do not control it. We do not sell it.

We can pray for it. We can obey. We can open the windows. But we cannot make it blow.

This is the difference between faith and magic. Magic tries to manipulate power. Faith asks the living God for mercy. Magic says the words and demands a result. Faith says the words and leaves the result with God. The prophet spoke; the wind blew. The servant was faithful; the dead rose. No one in the valley could call the resurrection an achievement.

That should make us humble. It should also make us hopeful. The God who is not controlled by our systems is free to do more than our systems can imagine.

The vision shows us two things at once.

First, the Word of God is necessary. The bones do not assemble without the prophecy. The gospel is not an optional accessory. Faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ. We must speak.

Second, the Spirit of God is necessary. The bones do not live without the breath. We can have the word and still be dead. We can have the truth and still be lifeless. We need the wind.

Word and Spirit. Both are God's. Both are given. Both are received by faith.

If we stop with the word, we become orthodox bones. If we chase the Spirit without the word, we become a wind without a body. The valley needs both.

Do not settle for a body without breath.

Do not settle for a church without life.

Do not settle for a Christianity that is all structure and no resurrection.

Pray for the wind.

The prophet prayed by prophesying. He spoke the words God gave him, and the breath came. You can pray a simple prayer: "Lord, breathe on these dry bones." It is a biblical prayer. It is a prayer that pleases God, because He loves to give life.

The Spirit is not a luxury for the spiritual elite. He is the breath of the church.

If you have been trying to live the Christian life on structure alone, you are trying to breathe without air. The answer is not more effort. The answer is the wind of God. Ask Him for it. He is not annoyed by that prayer; He is the one who put it in the Bible.

John Calvin called prayer the chief exercise of faith. We could also say that prayer is the lungs of the church. A church that does not pray is a church that is not breathing.

Ezekiel's valley teaches us to ask for the wind.

But the vision is not over. The army is standing. The valley is full of life. And God has something to say about what it all means.

Movement 5: The graves He will open

"Son of man, these bones are the whole house of Israel."

The vision has an interpretation. The bones are not a random collection of dead people. They are the house of Israel, the covenant people, the exiles who say, "Our hope is lost; we are cut off."

And God says, "I will open your graves and raise you from your graves, O my people. I will bring you into the land of Israel."

This is a promise of restoration. The exiles will come home. The nation will be rebuilt. The graves of Babylon will open, and the people will return to the land.

The first fulfillment was historical. Cyrus, the Persian king, conquered Babylon in 539 BC. He issued a decree allowing the exiles to return. Zerubbabel led a group back to Jerusalem. The foundations of the temple were laid. The altar was rebuilt. The walls were eventually rebuilt under Nehemiah. The people came home.

The return was real, but it was small. The crowds were fewer than the exiles who had been taken. The city was a province, not a kingdom. The temple was a building, not a throne. God had kept His promise, and the promise had not yet reached its fullness.

But the fulfillment was partial.

The second temple was smaller than the first. The old men who remembered the first temple wept when they saw the foundation of the second (Ezra 3:12). The glory did not fill it as it filled the temple of Solomon. The Davidic king did not return. The people were still under foreign rule. The sin was not gone. The graves were opened, but the nation still needed a deeper resurrection.

The prophets keep reaching for more.

Daniel 12:2 says, "Many of those who sleep in the dust of the earth shall awake, some to everlasting life, and some to shame and everlasting contempt." Isaiah 26:19 says, "Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise. You who dwell in the dust, awake and sing for joy!" The image of resurrection becomes the language of Israel's final hope.

Ezekiel's vision is primarily about the return from exile. But its imagery is too large to stay there. The God who opens the graves of a nation can open the graves of the dead.

That is not an allegory. It is the logic of the gospel. If God can bring a nation out of exile, He can bring a body out of the ground. If He can make a dead people live, He can make a dead sinner live. The resurrection is not a new idea; it is the same God doing the same kind of thing on a larger scale.

The New Testament tells us where this goes.

Jesus is the true Israel. He is the true Son of Man. He is the true Davidic King. He is the one who was buried, who went into the grave, and who rose on the third day. He is "the resurrection and the life" (John 11:25). He is the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep (1 Corinthians 15:20).

Jesus did not rise merely as a spirit. He rose in a body. The tomb was empty. He ate fish. He showed His hands and His side. He was raised in a glorified body, the firstfruits of a new creation. That is the guarantee that Ezekiel's promise is not just poetry.

And Jesus sends the Spirit. After the resurrection, He breathed on His disciples and said, "Receive the Holy Spirit" (John 20:22). At Pentecost, the Spirit came with a sound like a mighty rushing wind (Acts 2:2). The wind of God filled the church. The valley began to breathe.

The gospel is this: the God who said, "Can these bones live?" has answered the question in Jesus.

We were dead in our trespasses and sins. We were not sick, not weak, not just morally behind. We were dead. We walked with the world, followed the prince of the power of the air, lived in the passions of our flesh, and were by nature children of wrath, like the rest of mankind.

But God, being rich in mercy, because of the great love with which He loved us, even when we were dead in our trespasses, made us alive together with Christ. By grace we have been saved. He raised us up with Him and seated us with Him in the heavenly places in Christ Jesus (Ephesians 2:1–6).

That is the New Testament version of the valley. The bones do not assemble themselves. The dead do not contribute to their resurrection. God speaks, God breathes, and the dead live.

And the promise is not only for a nation, and not only for another time. It is for you, if you are in Christ.

"I will put my Spirit within you, and you shall live."

That is the new covenant.

Jeremiah promised it: "I will put my law within them, and I will write it on their hearts. And I will be their God, and they shall be my people" (Jeremiah 31:33). Ezekiel promised it in the chapter before this one: "I will give you a new heart, and a new spirit I will put within you. I will remove the heart of stone from your flesh and give you a heart of flesh. I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes" (Ezekiel 36:26–27).

The return from Babylon did not exhaust that promise. The new temple did not exhaust it. The resurrection of Jesus did not exhaust it. It will be exhausted in the new creation, when the dead are raised and the dwelling place of God is with man.

That is our hope. Not just that God will help us cope with the valley. But that He will open the graves.

Ezekiel's vision does not end with a surviving remnant. It ends with an army standing on its feet. The last word over the bones is not "dry." The last word is "live."

And that is the promise that holds when the casket is closed, when the diagnosis is terminal, when the church is empty, when the prodigal is still far off. It is not a promise that everything will be fixed in our preferred timetable. It is a promise that God is not done.

The valley breathes because God is the God who raises the dead.

Application: What do you do in the valley?

Ezekiel's vision is a vision, but it is not only for visionaries. It is for anyone standing among dry bones. What do we do when we are there?

1. Tell God the truth about the bones.

Do not pretend you are not in the valley. The exiles named their condition. The psalmists named theirs. Jesus named the grief of the world when He wept at Lazarus's tomb.

Lament is not a lack of faith. It is faith speaking to God from the ash heap. It is saying, "This is real, and You are God." It is refusing to let the dust have the last word by bringing the dust to the Lord.

If you are grieving, say it. If you are depressed, say it. If you are angry, say it. If your church is dead, say it. If your faith feels dry, say it. God already knows. He is not shocked by your honesty. He is grieved by a pretence that keeps Him at a distance.

But do not stop with the bones. The exiles said, "Our hope is lost." God answered, "I will open your graves." Lament is a doorway, not a destination. Tell God the truth, then ask Him to speak the truth back.

2. Stop asking dead bones to save themselves.

This is the core of the gospel, and it is the hardest thing for religious people to believe.

You cannot raise yourself. You cannot discipline yourself into resurrection. You cannot organize the bones into life. You cannot make a corpse breathe by giving it a better schedule.

The law can show you the bones. It cannot make them live. Moralism can arrange the skeleton. It cannot give the breath. Self-help can put flesh on the outside. It cannot create a new heart.

If you are trying to save yourself, you are asking the valley to do what only God can do. Stop. Look to the Lord. This is not an excuse for passivity; it is the beginning of real obedience. The prophet speaks because God commands him. You obey because God has raised you. Grace comes first; then the works.

The exiles had no future in themselves. Neither do we. But God does not ask us to produce our own life. He asks us to trust the one who raises the dead.

3. Speak the word and pray for the wind.

God uses means.

He could have raised the bones without a prophet. He chose to send one. He could have given life without a church. He chose to build one. He could have spoken directly to every heart. He chose the foolishness of preaching.

So speak.

Speak God's word to your children. Speak it to your friends. Speak it to your church. Speak it to the dry places in your own heart. Speak the truth, not your own opinions. Speak the gospel, not moralism. Speak with courage, not with a need to control the outcome.

But do not speak as if your words are the power. Pray for the wind.

Before you preach, pray. Before you teach, pray. Before you witness, pray. Before you serve, pray. Ask the Lord to send His Spirit. Ask Him to do what only He can do.

The vision has two commands, not one. Prophesy to the bones. Prophesy to the breath. Word and Spirit. Do both.

Some of us are good at speaking and poor at praying. We prepare the sermon, polish the outline, rehearse the transition, and never ask God to do anything. Others are good at praying and poor at speaking. We wait for a feeling and never open our mouths. The vision will not let us choose.

4. Do not settle for an assembled corpse.

It is possible to have a church that is right about everything and alive with nothing. It is possible to have a life that looks in order and is still dead.

The moment in the vision when the body is assembled but has no breath is a warning to us. It is possible to stop too soon. It is possible to be satisfied with bones in order.

Do not settle for a Christianity that is only structure. Do not settle for a ministry that is only management. Do not settle for a reputation that is only an image. Seek the Lord. Ask Him for the life that only His Spirit can give.

This does not mean we should chase every emotional experience or despise order. God is a God of order, and the Spirit is not a spirit of confusion. But order without life is a coffin. We want the bones to stand.

The end of the vision is a standing army. God does not raise the dead just so they can lie down in a nicer cemetery. He raises them to serve Him. The Spirit gives life for mission.

"You were dead in your trespasses and sins," Paul says, "but God made you alive with Christ." Why? "We are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works, which God prepared beforehand, that we should walk in them" (Ephesians 2:10).

Resurrection is for walking.

The vision ends with an army, not a choir. The life of God is given for the mission of God. If the breath has come, it will send you somewhere. If it has not, motion will not substitute for it.

The invitation

There are three kinds of people in this room.

The first is the person who is in the valley right now. You know the bones are dry. You can name the grave. You have stopped expecting anything. Jesus says, "I am the resurrection and the life."

He does not say, “Try harder.” He does not say, “Pretend you are not in a valley.” He says, “Come to me.”

The second is the person who has an assembled body but no breath. You are doing the right things, saying the right words, showing up at the right places. But something is dead inside. You have a form of godliness, but you do not know its power. Jesus says, “The wind blows where it wishes.” He invites you to ask for the Spirit.

The third is the person who has given up on someone else. You have watched a child, a spouse, a friend, a church dry out. You have decided that the bones are beyond hope. The Lord says, “Speak to the bones.” Do not give up on the person God has not given up on. Keep speaking the word. Keep praying for the wind. Leave the resurrection in God’s hands.

And all three of these people need the same Savior.

The gospel is not that the valley is not real. The gospel is that God entered the valley.

The invitation is not “try harder in the valley.” It is “come to the one who entered it.” Jesus is not a coach shouting from the rim. He is the Lord who came down into the grave and came out alive. If you are dead, He is your life. If you are dry, He is your rain. If you have no breath, He is the wind.

Jesus went into the grave. He took the death that was ours. He carried the curse that the dry bones deserved. He was buried. On the third day, the Father raised Him by the Spirit.

The tomb is empty.

The bones can live.

The valley can breathe.

Response

Take a moment of silence.

Ask yourself three questions.

Where are the dry bones in my life?

What would it look like to tell God the truth about them?

Who in my life needs me to speak God’s word and pray for the wind?

Write down one place. Do not write a plan to save yourself. Write a name. Write a prayer. Write one faithful step you can take this week: a conversation, a confession, a phone call, a return to church, a return to the Word, a return to the Lord.

If you are in a place of deep darkness, do not walk alone. Tell a trusted pastor, a counselor, a doctor, or a safe friend. The God who raises the dead can use medicine, therapy, and the care of His people. This sermon is not a demand to pretend you are not suffering. If you are in immediate danger, call your local emergency number; in the United States, you can call or text 988. Your life is precious to God.

Pray with me.

"Lord God, we are standing among bones. We have named our graves, and we cannot raise ourselves. But You are the God who breathes. You are the God who opened the tomb. You are the God who raises the dead.

Speak to our dry places. Breathe on our dead hearts. Send Your Spirit into our homes, our churches, our work, our witness. Make us alive together with Christ.

And when we see a valley, give us the courage to speak Your word and the faith to ask for the wind. Not to us, but to You be the glory. In Jesus' name, amen."

Closing

The valley did not breathe because the bones tried harder.

It breathed because the Word of the Lord came, and the Spirit of God blew.

Can these bones live?

Look at the empty tomb.

Yes. The valley breathes.

Evidence note for the preacher

This vision is one of the most familiar passages in Ezekiel, and familiarity can make us careless. Here are the main historical and theological points behind the sermon, with the confidence levels I would give them.

The vision and its setting. Ezekiel 37:1–14 has no date formula, but it follows the oracles of restoration after the fall of Jerusalem and belongs to the section of the book that looks forward to the new covenant, the restored land, and the Davidic prince (Ezekiel 36–37). Ezekiel is in Babylon, and the vision is a "hand of the LORD" experience: he is carried "in the Spirit" and set down in a valley (37:1). The location is visionary, not a geography we can map. "Valley" translates a Hebrew word for a broad plain or valley (biq'ah). The text describes bones on the surface of the ground, very many and very dry. The scene is of total death and exposure, not a normal cemetery.

"Son of man." The title does not appear here as the Daniel 7 messianic title. It is the Hebrew ben adam, "son of man," a way of addressing Ezekiel as a human being. It occurs more than ninety times in Ezekiel and emphasizes the prophet's mortality and his representative role. Preachers should not merge this title with Daniel 7 or with Jesus' self-designation without noting the difference. The New Testament does call Jesus the Son of Man and applies the Danielic title to Him, but the primary sense in Ezekiel 37 is human frailty.

"Very many" and "very dry." The Hebrew uses repetition and intensity: the bones are numerous and completely dry. This matters for the theology of the passage. The problem is not a lack of organization or a temporary setback. The bones have no life in themselves. Any interpretation that reduces the vision to a metaphor for discouragement misses the deliberate extremity of the image.

The people's lament. In 37:11 the bones are identified as "the whole house of Israel," and the people say, "Our bones are dried up, and our hope is lost; we are indeed cut off." This is a communal lament from the exile. The people are not making a private statement about emotional exhaustion; they are describing the death of a nation's future. The return from exile is the immediate promise: "I will open your graves and raise you from your graves, O my people. And I will bring you into the land of Israel" (37:12).

The two-stage animation. The bones assemble, but there is no breath in them (37:8). Only after the second prophecy does the breath enter (37:9–10). The sequence is explicit and theologically important: life is not the inevitable result of organization. Some interpreters see the two stages as corresponding to the return from exile and the later outpouring of the Spirit; the text does not make that correspondence explicit, but the sequence clearly distinguishes an assembled body from a living one. The sermon uses this as a warning against religion without the Spirit, not as an allegory for every detail.

Ruach. The Hebrew ruach means "wind," "breath," or "spirit," and the passage plays on all three senses. The ESV translates "breath" in verses 5, 6, 8, 9, and 10, and "Spirit" in verse 14. The wordplay is not an accident. The "four winds" in 37:9 suggest the fullness of the breath/Spirit coming from every direction. The New Testament's teaching on the Holy Spirit and the resurrection (John 3:8; 20:22; Acts 2; Romans 8:11) is a canonical development of this imagery, not a forced reading back into every line.

National restoration and resurrection. The primary referent of the vision is the restoration of exiled Israel. The bones are "the whole house of Israel" (37:11), and the graves are the exile from which God brings His people back to the land. This was fulfilled historically in the return from Babylon (538 BC onward) and the rebuilding of the temple. But the language of resurrection is too large to exhaust in the return, and later biblical revelation fills it out: Daniel 12:2, Isaiah 26:19, and the New Testament's doctrine of the resurrection. The sermon therefore moves from the historical return to the final resurrection and to Christ, while acknowledging the primary national referent. Preachers should not claim that Ezekiel 37 directly predicts the resurrection of Jesus without showing the canonical and theological steps.

The land. The promise of the land is a real historical promise to Israel, fulfilled in the return. It is not a warrant for deciding the details of modern Middle East politics, and the sermon does not use it that way. In the New Testament, the land promise is taken up into the greater inheritance of the new creation (Romans 8:18–25; Revelation 21–22). The theological trajectory is from Eden to Israel to Christ to the new heaven and new earth.

Christ and the Spirit. Jesus is the true Israel, the true Son of Man, and the true Davidic King. He was crucified, buried, and raised by the Spirit. He breathes the Spirit on His disciples (John 20:22), and the Spirit is poured out at Pentecost (Acts 2). Ephesians 2:1–10 applies the logic of Ezekiel's vision to every believer: we were dead, and God made us alive with Christ. The sermon's Christological reading is therefore canonical and modest: Jesus is the answer to the question "Can these bones live?", not an allegorical detail in every verse.

The Spirit and the church. The vision is not a promise that every church will grow or that every believer will feel alive. It is a promise that God can raise the dead, and it calls the church to depend on the Word and the Spirit rather than on structure alone. The application should avoid both triumphalism ("if we are faithful, everything will succeed") and defeatism ("the bones are too dry"). The text holds together human responsibility (prophesy) and divine sovereignty (the breath comes from God).

Care. Ezekiel's valley can be a meaningful text for people experiencing grief, depression, or spiritual dryness, but it can also be misused. The vision does not say that every valley is caused by personal sin, and it does not promise immediate relief. It says that God is able to raise the dead and that He is present in the valley. Preachers should include a care note: encourage professional and pastoral help for depression, trauma, and suicidal thoughts; do not tell suffering people to "just believe harder." The sermon's response includes a crisis note.

What I am most confident about. The identification of the bones with the house of Israel is explicit in the text. The ruach wordplay is clear. The two-stage animation is explicit. The call to prophesy and the divine "I will" statements are clear. The use of the passage in the New Testament's resurrection and Spirit theology is broad and canonical.

What I would hold more loosely. The exact date of the vision is not given. The identity of the "slain" in 37:9 is not specified; the interpretation identifies the bones with Israel, but the vision's imagery may evoke a battlefield. The precise relationship between the return from exile and the final resurrection is a matter of theological synthesis, not a direct statement in Ezekiel 37. The sermon should keep that distinction clear.

A final counsel. Do not preach this text as a pep talk about trying harder. The bones do not try. The prophet speaks, God breathes, and the dead live. Preach it as a resurrection text, and let the resurrection be God's work from beginning to end.